

Help for Families & Children

Raising a family on a tight budget is hard — and there's real help for food, cash, health coverage, and more. Single parents qualify for many of these too. Below are the main national starting points. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Many families who qualify never apply because they don't know these exist or assume they earn too much. Applying is free, and one application (like at your state benefits office) often covers several programs at once.

1 Cash & Food Help

Core programs that put money and food within reach each month.

☐ TANF — Temporary Cash Assistance

Monthly cash for families with children (and pregnant women) with little income. Apply through your state.

→ www.acf.hhs.gov/ofa/programs/temporary-assistance-needy-families-tanf

☐ SNAP — Food Benefits

Money for groceries each month. Many working families qualify. See the Food & Grocery guide.

→ www.fns.usda.gov/snap/recipient/eligibility

☐ 211 — Local Family Help

Call or search for local cash, food, and emergency help fast.

→ www.211.org or dial 211

2 Health Coverage for Kids & Parents

Free or low-cost coverage for your whole family.

☐ Medicaid & CHIP

Free or low-cost health coverage for children and many parents. Apply any time of year.

→ www.medicaid.gov/about-us/where-can-people-get-help-medicaid-chip/index.html

☐ Find a Community Health Center

Care for the whole family on a sliding scale, regardless of insurance.

→ findahealthcenter.hrsa.gov

3 Help for Single & Working Parents

Support that makes working and raising kids possible.

☐ **Child Care Assistance**

Help paying for child care so you can work or study. See the Child Care guide.

→ childcare.gov/consumer-education/get-help-paying-for-child-care

☐ **Child Support Services**

Free state help establishing and collecting child support.

→ www.acf.hhs.gov/css/parents

☐ **Head Start**

Free early education and care for young children in eligible families.

→ www.acf.hhs.gov/ohs/about/head-start

4 Local Hands-On Help

Agencies that bundle many services and help you apply.

☐ **Community Action Agency**

Local help with utilities, Head Start, emergency aid, and applying for benefits.

→ communityactionpartnership.com/find-a-cap

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Never pay a website to “apply for benefits” — TANF, SNAP, Medicaid, and the rest are free to apply for through your official state agency. Be wary of sites that mimic .gov pages and charge a fee.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Apply at your state benefits office (online or in person) — one application often screens you for cash, food, and health coverage together, so you don’t have to chase each program separately.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national programs. For your state’s benefits office and local family help, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area, and we’ll help you find the closest options.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
